

COMPARE THE WORK BEFORE YOU APPLY

PM or TPM

You can work on the same release as a product manager or a technical program manager. Both roles make decisions, work with engineers, and deal with problems that affect the launch. Before you apply, find out which decisions the job would put in your hands.

1 Ask which decisions you would own

A product manager works out which customer problems to address, what to prioritize, and how to measure whether the product helped. A technical program manager, or TPM, works through the technical plan across teams: how the systems connect, what could fail, and what needs to happen before the release.

The responsibilities overlap, so ask how this particular team divides the work.

EXAMPLE

Imagine a checkout redesign. The product manager might say, "Customers are abandoning payment. I want to test a shorter checkout before we add more features." The TPM might say, "The new checkout needs a change from the payments team. We need to agree on that change and test both systems together before we release."

Ask the hiring manager, "What's a recent decision someone in this role made?" Then ask who else was involved. You'll get a clearer picture of the job than you would from the title alone.

2 Get specific about the technical work

For a product role, look for customer research, prioritization, requirements, and product measures. For a technical program role, look for system design reviews, integration work, release planning, and technical risks.

The word "technical" needs an explanation from the team hiring you. Reading a design document, discussing how two services communicate, and writing production code are different expectations.

EXAMPLE

"When you say technical depth, would I review designs with the engineers, write code, or both? Could you walk me through a problem I'd be expected to handle?"

3 Compare the pay on the same basis

These are the US figures captured from Levels.fyi on September 5, 2026. They describe total compensation, including base salary, stock, and bonus, for the tech-focused samples used in this comparison.

Product manager: \$168,000 to \$330,000 at the 25th to 75th percentiles. Median: \$230,000. 90th percentile: \$455,000.

Technical program manager: \$182,000 to \$310,000 at the 25th to 75th percentiles. Median: \$240,000. 90th percentile: \$400,000.

The ranges cover the middle half of reported compensation. They aren't starting salaries or career limits, and these figures combine different companies, locations, and levels of experience. You can't use the higher TPM median to conclude that switching roles would raise your pay.

EXAMPLE

"What level is this opening, and what's the range for my location? How much is base salary, how much is stock, and is the bonus guaranteed or a target?"

Write those answers down for each opening. Then you can compare the cash you'd receive, the stock terms, and the work expected at that level.

4 Read the team description, not just the title

A product opening might cover one feature, an entire product, or an internal tool. A technical program opening might cover a software release, a hardware program, or a change that several engineering teams need to make together.

Search both full titles in the locations where you'd work. Company size alone won't tell you which jobs are available or what those teams expect.

EXAMPLE

"Which teams would I work with? What would I be responsible for in my first three months, and who owns that work today?"

If an opening mixes product and program responsibilities, ask how much time you'd spend on each. You can then decide whether that combination suits you before accepting it.

5 Check what comes after the job

In product management, possible next roles include senior product manager, group product manager, director, or VP of Product. Technical program management can include senior and principal roles, plus management positions such as Director of Technical Program Management.

The sequence depends on the company. A principal role can involve leading larger programs without managing people. Moving into another function brings different requirements.

EXAMPLE

"Can someone grow here without becoming a people manager? What changed in the work of the last person you promoted?"

6 Use a project you've actually worked on

Pick one project you've worked on and write down your part in it.

For product management, explain the problem, the evidence you used, the options you considered, and how you judged the result.

For technical program management, describe the teams involved, how their work depended on each other, a technical risk, and what you did to resolve it.

EXAMPLE

If your experience is mostly coordinating deadlines, you could ask an engineer, "Can we walk through why this dependency is blocking the release? I want to understand the technical problem before I update the plan."

Use these prompts to prepare your interview example. Leave a gap where you don't have the experience yet:

- ☐ The project and my responsibility:
- ☐ The customer or business problem:
- ☐ A decision I made and the evidence I used:
- ☐ A technical dependency or risk I worked through:
- ☐ What changed, with a result I can support:
- ☐ The experience this opening asks for that I still need:

Sources for the pay figures: Levels.fyi US role pages, captured September 5, 2026. Check the current figures before using them in a negotiation.

Product Manager: <https://www.levels.fyi/t/product-manager?countryId=254>

Technical Program Manager: <https://www.levels.fyi/t/technical-program-manager?countryId=254>

Role example: Amazon Jobs, Technical Program Manager, Global Product Expansion, job 3008762. The dialogue and checkout scenario in this guide are illustrative, not accounts of Dennis's work.